descendant of ours, studying Sweden in early twenty-first century, looked at the Swedish books of that period, she would find a high proportion of crime fiction and may conclude that crime was a major concern there compared to other countries. In fact, Sweden has a relatively low crime rate but a penchant for crime thrillers. A good historian cultivates a fine-tuned radar to assess what conclusions are supportable by what evidence.

Unfortunately, historians can also be accomplices in political games. Some, more than others, interpret past events to favour a particular group. While it's true that no one owns history, some historians are clearly more partisan—like those who wilfully flout or conjure up evidence, or are led by a hegemonic sense of identity. Such history writing—often zealously undertaken from what is defined as 'our perspective'—is less about elevating scholarship, and more about honing majoritarian pride in a social group. Histories written from such insular points of view thrive by inflating the fears, resentments and tribal affinities in the reader—and exacerbate civil and communal strife.

In my storytelling, I wish to promote neither pride nor shame in our past, but to increase understanding of the diverse and complex journeys of our ancestors. I see the past as a dynamic interplay of migration, conflict, mixing, coexistence and cooperation led by various existential motives. I write not from any 'our' perspective but from *my* perspective, which accounts for both cultural and material factors, and is not aligned with any single ideological view. I've gained from many views and aspire to be as fair-minded as I can be, while striving for intimacy, immersion and analysis. I'm not inclined to take pride in things I did not help create, but I do believe in celebration and wonder—and there is plenty in the Indian past worthy of both, as I hope the reader will find in the following pages. At the end of the day, what will always make a 'better story' of the past is the reader's discernment in the present.

The Arc of My Story

Following this introduction, six chapters on major sites alternate with five chapters on major travellers. In this way, I zoom across nearly 5000 years of India's past while reflecting on some of its most brilliant eras—and their breaks and continuities with Indian social life today.